

3, Historians' Lack of Caution and Comprehension Regarding "Solving the Grand Case"

Readers presumably still remember that my major during both my undergraduate and graduate studies was mathematics; I have received absolutely not a single shred of formal academic training within the realm of the social sciences.

There was only a singular reason I initially embarked upon researching these macroscopic propositions: an endeavor to figure out precisely why Chinese society mutated into the exact state I witness today. Although I was fond of reading Chinese historical records from a phenomenally young age (*naturally, at that time I relied heavily upon vernacular translation editions*), I must concede that when I first entered my undergraduate studies, I fundamentally barely considered historical issues. Recalling it now, I feel I was exceedingly naive back then; I genuinely believed that comprehending societal mutations only required considering history within a short timeframe.

What exact force compelled me to grow suspicious? The answer is that the propaganda I heard every day, the theories I learned every day, and the factual reality I witnessed every day perpetually failed to align. I discovered that the distinction between the social sciences and the mathematics major I was studying is genuinely astronomically vast. The mathematics major is predicated upon formal logic; it fundamentally requires absolutely no physical experiments to prove it. Conversely, in the social sciences, no matter how rational or how convincing a theory might sound, what can genuinely prove its validity must be factual reality. At that time, I began to sense that while the social sciences naturally cannot divorce themselves from scientific theory, they behave far more akin to an experimental science; rendering judgments relying exclusively upon formal logic is phenomenally dangerous.

Shortly thereafter, I realized exactly how colossal the distinction is between this unique experimental science and the experimental sciences within the natural sciences, such as chemistry. For the natural sciences, provided the technological conditions are sufficient, we can design experiments, record experimental outcomes, or replicate experiments based upon the papers of others. But regarding the social sciences, could we possibly genuinely use a human society to conduct experiments?

On the one hand, it is an issue of feasibility. For instance, in the 21st century, it is fundamentally impossible for us to command a society of millions to simulate the historical process of the initial centuries of **feudalization** (封建化). On the other hand, it entails extreme peril. Experiments in the natural sciences can basically be effectively controlled, but if one uses a society to conduct an experiment, exactly how can one guarantee the safety of the lives and property of millions of people?

This is an exceedingly critical juncture. Since we can neither design nor replicate experiments, we are structurally compelled to excavate those pre-existing experimental outcomes—namely, what people commonly term "history." Setting aside humanistic concerns temporarily and speaking strictly from a utilitarian standpoint: the history of humanity constitutes page after page of experimental reports encompassing all societal experiments; historiography (历史学) is precisely the discipline of authenticating and analyzing these experimental reports; historians are the individuals authenticating and analyzing these experimental reports; and historiographical methodology is the method of authenticating and analyzing these experimental reports.

Only by meticulously authenticating the veracity of these experimental reports, illuminating the concealed relationships among the experimental data, isolating those precious and unique samples, extracting robust control groups, and restoring the conditions under which these experiments were conducted as maximally as possible, can we possibly discern the underlying laws governing human societal development revealed behind these experiments. These experimental reports, serving as the bedrock of factual reality, are fundamentally irreplaceable by any theoretical deduction whatsoever. Consequently, I was compelled to focus my attention upon human history—initially the history of my own nation, and subsequently, gradually necessitating a comprehension of the history of the entire world.

Yet even so, matters still did not proceed in the anticipated direction. I rapidly realized that I was not merely unlocking a dust-covered warehouse to retrieve and research records deposited eons ago; rather, I was "dragged into" a criminal case—a heaven-shaking grand case concerning the very origins of humanity. Starting from October 2022, I discovered that historical research, or broader sociological research, is absolutely not merely a struggle against documents; it is the process of cracking a series of cases perpetrated by a constellation of criminal syndicates of varying proficiencies.

Why do I employ such a metaphor? Because proceeding from the experience I have accumulated over these past few years, I maintain that researching history from the perspective of criminal investigation (刑侦) indeed yields substantial benefits, and historical research is highly likely vastly more arduous than criminal investigation. The reasons are as follows:

First, historical research is not locating archives within an archive room. Archives within an archive room are categorically arranged in chronological order. However, in historical research, the events we comprehend *first* do not necessarily precede the events we comprehend *later* upon the chain of causality. This is exactly identical to solving a criminal case: does the event pointed to by the first-discovered evidence necessarily predate the event pointed to by the later-discovered evidence? Unquestionably not.

Furthermore, during an investigation, the investigator invariably encounters new evidence; occasionally, the emergence of new evidence utterly demolishes the original logical chain—this is phenomenally normal. However, an investigative team usually maintains highly concentrated mental focus while cracking a case, and the duration is relatively brief; therefore, police and detectives can perpetually retain this awareness in their minds. The process of historical research itself spans colossal temporal dimensions; it is highly probable that one piece of evidence is discovered long before another piece of evidence surfaces, with the interim perhaps spanning several generations of scholars. Consequently, the earlier evidence is exceedingly prone to being endowed with an overly elevated priority, propelling the academic community to forge certain preconceived dogmas; attempting to shatter such dogmas subsequently becomes phenomenally arduous.

Second, exactly as I have stated previously, historical documents and even archaeological evidence can "lie" (说谎). This is identically the same as collecting evidence at a crime scene. Which detective can guarantee that the testimonies of all eyewitnesses are exclusively the truth? Which police officer can determine with absolute certainty that every single trace was not deliberately planted by the perpetrator to misdirect the investigation?

This defenseless naivete is exceptionally glaringly manifest among Western historians (*and identical for the Japanese*). I am not asserting that Western historical documents are necessarily that much more credible, but according to my observation, they ostensibly have absolutely never witnessed an organized, purposeful, systemic campaign of forgery that spanned millennia. If detectives and police officers unthinkingly believe every shred of testimony and every piece of crime scene evidence, then there is zero reason they would not be deceived by perpetrators possessing supreme intellect and formidable execution capacity.

Third, vastly more arduous than cracking a criminal case is the fact that in historical research, it is fundamentally impossible to genuinely apprehend any suspect or subject them to interrogation. On the contrary, this suspect might perpetually exist, continuously and deliberately interfering with historical research; I presume that by this point, everyone knows exactly what I am referring to.

This is a phenomenally complex issue. Imagine what occurs in a novel if the perpetrator's power is colossal: they would not only possess abundant mechanisms for forgery and methods for exoneration, but naturally, they would identically interfere with the investigation of the case. Exactly what rationale would they possess *not* to do so? Is it possible for the suspect to masquerade as the victim and cry foul? Is it possible for them to return to the crime scene to deliberately create havoc? At the very least, one fundamentally cannot preclude such possibilities.

Fourth, when the police are cracking a case, they can at least forcibly secure the crime scene. Yet what can historians do? *De facto*, what they can accomplish is exceedingly limited: the crime scenes are too colossal, too multitudinous, and frequently, their exact locations remain completely unknown before they are serendipitously identified. Relatively concentrated evidence with high information density, such as documents, is easily destroyed or tampered with; meanwhile, the multitudinous scattered historical relics are phenomenally arduous to comprehensively protect.

Distinct from actual criminal cases, what economic value could the physical evidence of a crime scene hold for ordinary people? Excluding perpetrators harboring anomalous fetishes, would anyone genuinely collect the knife used to kill the victim or the victim's clothing? Yet the circumstances historians confront are entirely different. Artifacts unearthed through archaeological excavation genuinely command exorbitant prices; consequently, individuals entirely unconnected to the "case" can destroy the scene purely driven by their own interests.

As far as I know, regardless of the locale globally, the smuggling of cultural relics remains perpetually irrepressible despite repeated prohibitions. Even if an artifact is recovered, the information it originally carried has already suffered colossal depletion. For instance, in exactly what posture and alongside exactly what other artifacts was this specific piece positioned? Looters obviously possess zero inclination to care about such issues. However, for cracking the "case," this contextual information might be even more paramount than the artifact itself. For those cultural relics and historical sites temporarily arduous to protect, contemporary archaeologists can only strive to preserve visual and textual records as maximally as possible—naturally, with advanced modern technology, they can execute 3D modeling; their labor is exceptionally grueling yet profoundly meaningful.

Every time a single experimental report of human history vanishes, it is permanently lost; who can guarantee that this specific report was not the key to unlocking the truth? Yet once it is lost, no one will ever know its value again!

Fifth, criminal investigations and historical research possess astronomical disparities regarding the temporal dimensions involved. For historians, new information perpetually overwrites older information; this is a reality against which one is absolutely powerless. No one possesses the authority to order a nation: *Stop developing immediately; maintain the current societal state unaltered for 500 years!*

Not only will physical evidence erode, but human memories will identically blur. Once monumental mutations occur in the **social being** (社会存在), several centuries later, people's memories concerning the preceding era will become egregiously distorted, and at this juncture, false memories (虚假的记忆) will inevitably run rampant. Whenever I reflect upon the assertions formulated by Karl Marx (马克思) and Friedrich Engels (恩格斯) during their era, I feel astounded, yet I must simultaneously concede that this was not a problem exclusive to those two.

How many individuals of that era affirmatively denounced the depravity and filth of capitalism (资本主义)? Yet the problem is: was the pre-industrial society (前工业社会)—the world prior to the genesis of capitalism—some utopian paradise of benevolence and righteousness? People can naturally criticize British factories for employing such massive quantities of child labor, but what I wish to articulate is that had those exact children been born in the concurrent Qing Dynasty (清朝), they would likely have starved to death long ago, and infant girls would highly likely have been murdered the exact moment they were born!

Capitalism allegedly plunged interpersonal relations into cold calculations measured strictly by money; but was society genuinely a "Great Harmony" (大同社会) prior to the emergence of capitalism? In an era where starvation followed humanity like a shadow, exactly what ethics and morals could conceivably exist among individuals? At that time, how many years had elapsed since Germany departed the Late Middle Ages? Merely a little over three centuries. But China has already endured fourteen centuries within a **restoration-bureaucratic society** (复辟官僚社会)! Today, people can solely rely upon the imagination reconstructed from documents and archaeological evidence, alongside analogies to similar societies, to comprehend the more chronologically remote ancient China.

Therefore, I maintain that researchers in sociology, and particularly historians, perhaps genuinely ought to study specific methods of criminal investigation; surely they identically feel humiliated upon realizing they have been deceived! At the absolute minimum, they ought to elevate their vigilance. They cannot possibly indiscriminately believe every word spoken or deem every recorded event to be factual reality; one must unequivocally insist upon maintaining independent thought and judgment! Myriad conclusions ought to be deliberated thrice prior to articulation. After all, the social sciences directly dictate the welfare of humanity; preventing one's own errors from inflicting suffering upon the populace constitutes the most fundamental ethical imperative (基本的義理).

3, 历史学家对于“侦破大案”的困难缺乏谨慎和认识

读者想必还记得我本科和研究生的专业是数学, 没有受过社会科学领域一点半点的科班训练。我最开始研究这些宏大命题的原因只有一个, 那就是试图搞清楚为什么中国社会会变成我看到的这个样子。尽管我在很小的年纪就喜欢读中国的史书, 当然那个时候还非常借助于白话翻译版本, 可是我必须承认在我刚上本科时根本不怎么考虑历史问题。现在我回忆起来觉得当年很幼稚, 我曾经确实为了解社会变迁只需要考虑短时段内的历史就够了。是什么力量让我起疑呢? 回答是我天天听到的宣传, 天天学到的理论和我天天见到的事实总是对不上。我发现社会科学和我学习的数学专业区别真的很大, 数学专业

讲的就是形式逻辑，它根本不需要什么实验来证明。相反，社会科学中的每一个理论无论听起来多么合理，多么令人信服，真正能证明其有效的必须是事实。那时我开始感到社会科学当然离不开科学理论，但它更像一门实验科学，仅凭形式逻辑做出判断是非常危险的。

不久之后我就意识到了这门独特的实验科学跟自然科学中的实验科学比如化学相比有多大的区别。对于自然科学来说，只要技术条件足够，我们就可以设计实验，记录实验结果，也可以根据别人的论文重复实验。但是对于社会科学来说，难道我们真的拿一个社会做实验吗？一方面是可行性的问题，比如说在 21 世纪我们不可能再让一个几百万人口的社会模拟一下封建化初期几个世纪的历史进程。另一方面是具有极大的危险性，自然科学实验基本上都可以有效得到控制，但是拿一个社会做实验怎么保证上百万人的生命和财产安全呢？这是一个很关键的点，我们既然不能设计实验和重复实验，就不得不挖掘那些已有的实验结果，也就是人们常说的“历史”。暂且压下人文关怀不谈而仅功利地讲，人类的历史就是一页页人类社会一切实验的报告，历史学就是辨别和分析这些实验报告的学问，历史学家就是辨别和分析这些实验报告的人，历史学方法就是辨别和分析这些实验报告的方法。只有精确地辨别这些实验报告的真伪，清楚实验数据之间所隐藏的关系，找到那些珍贵的独一无二的样本，提取出良好的对照组，尽可能还原这些实验进行时的情况，我们才能看到这些实验背后所揭示的有关人类社会规律。这些实验报告作为事实的支撑是任何理论推导都代替不了的，因此我就不得不关注人类的历史，最初是自己国家的历史，然后慢慢地需要把全世界的历史都了解一些。

可是即使这样的事情仍然没有按照预想的方向发展，我很快意识到我不是打开一个尘封的仓库，然后从里面找到很久以前的记录进行研究，而是“卷进”了一个案件当中，一个关于人类来路的惊天大案。从 2022 年 10 月开始，我发现历史研究或者更大一点的社会学研究绝非只是和资料做斗争，而是破获一群水平不同的犯罪团伙所犯下的一系列案件。为什么我采取这样的比喻呢？因为我从我自己几年以来积累的经验出发，认为从刑侦的角度研究历史的确是有好处的，并且历史研究比刑侦很可能难度更大。有如下几个原因。

第一，历史研究不是在档案室里找档案。档案室里的档案都是按照时间顺序排列的，但是在历史研究中，我们先了解的事件在因果链上不一定早于后了解的事件。这一点与案件侦破时是一模一样的，难道先发现的证据所指向的事件就比后发现的证据早吗？肯定不是如此。更何况在调查中侦破者总会遇到新证据，有的时候新证据的出现会把原先的逻辑链完全推翻，这再正常不过了。然而，一个破案团队在侦破案件的过程中往往精神高度集中，时间持续得也比较短，因此警察和侦探总是能够在意识中牢记这一点。历史研究的过程本身涉及的时间跨度就很大，很可能一个证据发现很久之后才有另一个证据，这期间或许经历了好几代人。那么早前的证据就很容易被赋予过高的优先级，使得学界形成某种先入为主的观念，想要破除这种观念就很困难了。

第二，就像我在之前已经说过的，历史文献甚至考古证据都可以“说谎”，这一点跟案发现场取证时是一样的。哪个侦探能够保证目击人的证词都是实话？哪个警察可以确定每一处痕迹都不是罪犯故意留下误导案件侦破的呢？这种毫无防备的天真在西方历史学家（日本也一样）身上体现得尤为明显，我不是说西方的历史文献就一定多可信，但是据我观察他们似乎完全没有见过一种长达上千年的，有组织，有目的，系统性的造假运动。如果侦探和警察不假思索地相信每一段证词，每一处现场证据，那么他们就没有理由不被高智商和高执行力的罪犯所欺骗。

第三，比侦破案件更为困难的是，历史研究非但不可能真正抓捕什么嫌疑人，对他进行审讯。这个嫌疑人反而可能一直存在，并且有意地对历史研究进行干扰，相信到这里大家都知道我在说什么。这是一个非常复杂的问题，想一想在小说中如果罪犯势力颇大会怎么样，那么他不但拥有充足的造假手段，脱罪的办法，而且当然会对案件侦破进行干扰，他有什么理由不这么做呢？嫌疑人有没有可能伪装成受害者叫冤？有没有可能回到案发现场进行捣乱？至少不能排除这种可能。

第四，警方在破案时至少可以强行保护案发现场，但是历史学家能怎么做呢？实际上能做得非常有限，案发现场太大，太多，甚至很多时候在被认出来之前根本不知道在哪。相对集中的，信息密度大的证据，例如文献容易被销毁和篡改；而众多分散的历史遗迹又难以进行全面的保护。不同于实际的案件，案发现场的物证对于普通人来说能有什么经济价值？除了有特殊癖好的罪犯，有人会收藏杀死受害人的刀或者受害人的衣物吗？可是历史学家面临的情况不一样，考古发掘出的文物来说是真的可以卖到高价的，因此与案件无关的人员也可以出于自己的利益破坏现场。据我所知，无论在全世界的哪个地方，文物走私都处于一种屡禁不止的状态。就算文物被追回，它身上所承载的信息也已经损失了太多，比如这

个文物曾经是以什么样的姿态和什么样的其他文物一起摆放在什么样的位置？盗掘者显然不太可能关心这种问题。然而，对破案来说，这种信息甚至会比文物本身更重要。对于那些暂时难以保护的文物古迹，现在的考古学者只能尽可能地留下图像和文字记录，当然现在技术先进了能够 3D 建模，他们的工作是十分辛苦却很有意义的。人类历史的实验报告消失一份就永远少了一份，谁能保证这份报告不是揭示真理的钥匙？可是一旦失去就不会再有人知道它的价值了！

第五，案件侦破和历史研究在涉及的时间跨度上有天壤之别。对于历史学家来说，新的信息总是在覆盖旧的信息，这是绝对无可奈何的事情。没有人有权力要求一个国家说：立刻停下不许发展，维持现有社会状态 500 年不变！不但实物证据会磨灭，人们的记忆也会模糊。一旦社会存在发生巨变，几个世纪之后，人们对于上一个时期的记忆就会变得极其模糊，这个时候虚假的记忆必然大行其道。我每每想到马克思、恩格斯当年做出的论断就感到惊诧，可是却不得不承认这又不只是他们两个人的问题。那个年代有多少人肯定地指出了资本主义的罪恶和肮脏，问题是难道前工业社会，资本主义诞生之前的世界是什么王道乐土吗？人们当然可以批评英国的工厂雇用了如此之多的童工，但是我想说的是那些孩子如果生在同时期的清朝，他们恐怕早就饿死了，而女孩子甚至很可能刚出生就被杀害！资本主义让人们彼此之间陷入用金钱衡量的冰冷关系，难道在资本主义出现前就是大同社会吗？在饥饿如影随形的年代，人与人间又有什么伦理道德可言？那个时候德国距离中世纪晚期过了多少年呢？也不过三个世纪多一些。但是中国已经在复辟官僚社会度过了十四个世纪啊！人们现在只能凭借文献和考古证据重构的想象和相似社会的类比来理解更久远的古代中国了。

因此我认为社会学研究者特别是历史学家或许真的应该学习一些刑侦的方法，他们想必也会对自己被欺骗感到耻辱吧！最起码应该提高警惕心，总不能什么话都信，什么事都认为是真的，一定要坚持自己的思考和判断啊！很多结论应当三思而后言，毕竟社会科学直接关系到人类的福祉，不让自己的错误使百姓受难是最基本的义理。